PHISHING AWARENESS

Target audience: Teams A and B
Priority: teams identified as most susceptible in the simulation

Pause. Check. Report.

A practical guide to spotting suspicious messages and protecting company information.

One click can expose passwords, financial data, or the wider organization. A few seconds of checking can prevent it.

1. What is phishing?

Phishing is a social-engineering attack in which a criminal pretends to be a trusted person or organization to trick someone into revealing information, opening a harmful attachment, or visiting a fake website.

EMAIL	TEXT / CHAT	PHONE / QR
A fake message from IT asks you to “verify” your account.	A delivery notice or colleague’s urgent message includes an unexpected link.	A caller pressures you to share a code, or a QR code leads to a counterfeit login page.

Why Teams A and B? The simulation identified these as the priority audiences for additional coaching. The goal is learning and safer habits—not blame. Treat every unexpected request as something to verify.

2. Red flags: spot the pressure tactics

RED FLAG	WHAT IT CAN LOOK LIKE	SAFER RESPONSE
Urgency or threats	“Your account will be closed in 10 minutes.”	Slow down. Verify through a known, trusted channel.
Unexpected links	A login link with a misspelled or unfamiliar domain.	Hover to inspect the destination; navigate to the official site yourself.
Unexpected attachments	An invoice, shared document, or package notice you did not expect.	Confirm with the sender before opening; follow company reporting procedures.
Requests for secrets	A request for your password, MFA code, or payment details.	Never share passwords or one-time codes in response to a message.
Odd sender or tone	A familiar name with a strange address, unusual wording, or unexpected request.	Check the full address and contact the person using known details.

Remember: polished branding and a familiar display name do not prove a message is legitimate.

3. Practice: would you trust this email?

SUBJECT: ACTION REQUIRED — Mailbox access expires today

From: IT Support <it-helpdesk.security-check@example-mail.com>

Your mailbox will be disabled in 30 minutes. Click RE-AUTHENTICATE NOW and enter your password and verification code to keep access. Do not contact the help desk because this request is automated.

SPOT THE CLUES

- Artificial urgency and threat of losing access
- Unfamiliar sender domain
- Requests for both a password and MFA code
- Tells you not to verify independently

WHAT TO DO

Do not click or reply. Open your company’s known IT portal or contact the help desk using a trusted directory. Report the message using your organization’s approved process.

This is a fictional training example. Real phishing messages may be more subtle and may imitate legitimate brands.

4. The 20-second response plan

1	**PAUSE**	Do not rush because a message says “urgent.”
2	**INSPECT**	Check the sender, request, links, and context.
3	**VERIFY**	Use a known website, phone number, or internal directory—not the message’s link or number.
4	**REPORT**	Use the approved phishing-reporting button or contact your IT/security team.

IF YOU CLICKED OR SHARED INFORMATION

Report it immediately—even if you are unsure. Follow IT/security instructions, change a compromised password through the official site, and never hide a mistake. Fast reporting can limit damage.

Team commitment: Before acting on an unusual request, pause and verify. When in doubt, report it.